

MANAGE YOUR CAREER

The first rule is to manage your career. Making more money in your present job or switching to a new one can make the difference between retiring at age 40 or at age 70.

When people hear that I retired at 35 they often get a shrewd look on their faces. "Real estate, huh?" I shake my head. "Oil wells?" I shake my head. "Stock market?" Again I shake my head. They get desperate. "What the hell did you do? Rob a bank?"

All I did was become a partner in a big accounting firm. It's no secret that partners in the big accounting firms enjoy substantial incomes. And it's no secret that it's easier to build your net worth with a substantial income than with two-dollar tips.

I'm being a little cavalier when I tell you to go out and make more money. If it were so easy to get a high-paying job you'd probably have one already. And you may enjoy being a poorly paid teacher, nurse, letter carrier, journalist, or librarian, thank you. If a job you enjoy pays \$20,000 a year, well, that's what it pays. Life's too short to give up willy-nilly a fun, rewarding job just to make a few bucks.

But you may not have to change jobs to make more money. In a July 1986 *Boston Globe* article on career changing, Sarah Snyder reports that "if there is a consensus among career counselors . . . it is that people tend to overlook ways to make a current job more fulfilling." More fulfilling, in most cases, means more money as well. Cynthia Scott, co-author with Dennis Jaffe of *From Burnout to Balance* (McGraw-Hill, 1984), says that before changing careers, you should push your present job to the limits of its challenge—and remuneration.

If you're a computer programmer you can become a systems analyst and then a computer salesman. If you're a legal assistant you can go to night school and become a lawyer. If you're a doctor you can become head of a hospital. If you're a store assistant you can become a store manager and then a store owner.